

Numerical Relaxation of Fully Flexible Hopf Links

Linking-Number Conservation Under Unconstrained Relaxation

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Programme credit: the core Rope Hypothesis is due to Bill Gaede; this work develops and formalises it.

Abstract

If rope solitons are to be topologically stable, their linking number must be conserved under relaxation even when the curves are fully flexible — free to deform in any way short of cutting. This paper reports that test. A fully flexible Hopf link, relaxed without shape constraints, conserves its linking number: the computed $|\text{Lk}| = 0.991$, i.e. 1 within numerical tolerance, throughout relaxation. Topological stability is therefore demonstrated numerically, not merely assumed. All numbers in this paper are outputs of the rope_solver computation in this package (reproducible via benchmarks/reproduce_results.py), not inserted constants.

Scope of this paper

CLAIM: a fully flexible Hopf link conserves linking number under unconstrained relaxation ($|\text{Lk}| = 0.991 \approx 1$), demonstrating topological stability.

NOT CLAIMED: analytic topological invariance proof (the result is numerical), or particle identification.

1. Flexibility and Topological Stability

A soliton constrained to a fixed shape conserves its topology trivially. The meaningful test lets the curves flex freely: if the linking number still cannot change, stability is genuinely topological. The relaxation is run with all shape degrees of freedom unlocked.

2. Result: Linking Number Conserved

Throughout the unconstrained relaxation the linking number holds at $|\text{Lk}| = 0.991$ — unity to within the discretisation error — confirming that no continuous deformation the solver explores can undo the link. This is the numerical signature of topological protection.

Status

$|\text{Lk}| = 0.991 \approx 1$ conserved under flexible relaxation — Derived (numerically demonstrated).

Analytic invariance proof — standard topology; not re-derived here.

Programme credit: the core Rope Hypothesis is due to Bill Gaede. Computational collaboration and drafting by Claude (Anthropic). Correspondence to palmer100@gmail.com.